

The Alphabet Tree

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“Because not so long ago this tree was full of letters. They lived a happy life, hopping from leaf to leaf on the highest twigs

Each letter had its favorite leaf, where it would sit in the sun and rock in the gentle breeze of spring.

One day the breeze became a strong gust and the gust became a gale.

The letters clung to the leaves with all their might—but some were blown away, and the others were very frightened.

When the storm had passed they huddled together in fear, deep in the foliage of the lower branches.

A funny bug, red and black with bright yellow wings, saw them there, hiding in the shade.

‘We are hiding from the wind,’ the letters explained. ‘But who are you?’

‘I am the word-bug,’ the bug answered. ‘I can teach you to make words. If you get together in threes and fours, and even more, no wind will be strong enough to blow you away.’

Patiently he taught the letters to join together and make words.

Some made short and easy words like dog and cat, others learned to make more difficult ones: twig, leaf, and even earth.

Happily they climbed back onto the highest leaves, and when the wind came they held on without fear. The word-bug had been right.

Then, one summer morning, a strange caterpillar appeared amid the foliage. He was purple, woolly, and very large. ‘Such confusion!’ said the caterpillar when he saw the words scattered around the leaves.

‘Why don’t you get together and make sentences—and mean something?’

The letters had never thought of this. Now they could really write—say things. They said things about the wind, the leaves, the bug. ‘Good!’ said the caterpillar approvingly. ‘But not good enough.’

‘Why?’ asked the letters, surprised.

‘Because you must say something important,’ said the caterpillar.

The letters tried to think of something important, really important. Finally they knew what to say. What could be more important than peace? PEACE ON EARTH AND GOODWILL TOWARD ALL MEN, they spelled excitedly.

‘Great!’ said the caterpillar. ‘Now climb onto my back.’ One by one the letters climbed onto the woolly back. ‘But where are you taking us?’ they asked anxiously, as the caterpillar began climbing down the tree.

‘To the President,’ said the caterpillar.”

Meaningful text within the illustrations

- Pages 13, 17 and 18 show individual letters scattered through the tree rather than continuous prose.
- Pages 22 and 24 show the letters beginning to form words. Clearly readable examples include cat, bug, leaf, tree, red, you, zoo, small, big, earth, peace and now.
- Pages 27, 28 and 29 show words being rearranged in preparation for sentences.
- Page 30 includes readable leaf-sentences such as ‘the wind is bad’, ‘leaves are green’ and ‘the bug is small’. These are part of the illustration as well as the narrative meaning.
- Pages 32–34 show the final peace message extending across the leaves and the caterpillar.